

THE OBSIDIAN-EXCALIDRAW VISUAL THINKING GUIDE

A Concise Reference Manual Summarizing 57 Key Features for Personal Knowledge Management

Excalidraw in Obsidian is not just a vector drawing tool; it is a visual thinking powerhouse that turns text notes into interactive, infinite-canvas knowledge maps. This tutorial synthesizes the 57 key features from the showcase video, giving you a structured guide to build high-performance visual workflows. Follow these essential techniques and setups.

1. CORE DRAWING AND ALIGNMENT FOUNDATIONS

- **Basic Shapes & Key Shortcuts:** Speed up drawing by using hotkeys next to each shape in the toolbar. Quickly instantiate rectangles, ellipses, lines, or arrows.
- **Snap to Objects:** Draw aligned schematics effortlessly. The canvas automatically snaps shapes into place and sizes them relative to nearby elements for clean geometry.
- **Set Grid Script:** Customize your workspace background. Download 'Set Grid' from the built-in Script Store to modify the grid size, color, and line thickness.
- **Stencil Library Integration:** Save assets locally using the context menu's 'Add to Library'. Browse community-made visual stencils, download them, and import them into your local vault.
- **Workspace UI Modes:** Use 'Tray Mode' to keep property panels hidden and maximize canvas space. Switch to 'Normal Mode' to access the standard excalidraw.com web layout.

2. VISUAL CONNECTIONS (LINKING AND TRANSLUDING)

- **Vault Note Linking:** Right-click any shape and select 'Insert Link to File' to connect it to an Obsidian note. Hold Ctrl/Cmd while hovering over the link to open an interactive pop-up preview.
- **Block Reference Transclusion:** Bring specific text blocks from markdown files onto your drawing using transclusion, ensuring that your text and drawings update dynamically.
- **Back-of-the-Note Cards:** Level 1 headers within your Excalidraw drawing file function as the 'back' of drawing cards. Add tables, templates, or scripts, and edit them seamlessly in markdown view.
- **Interactive Frame Embedding:** Insert scalable, live web frames by dragging and dropping URLs. Hold Shift while resizing to lock and preserve their exact aspect ratio.

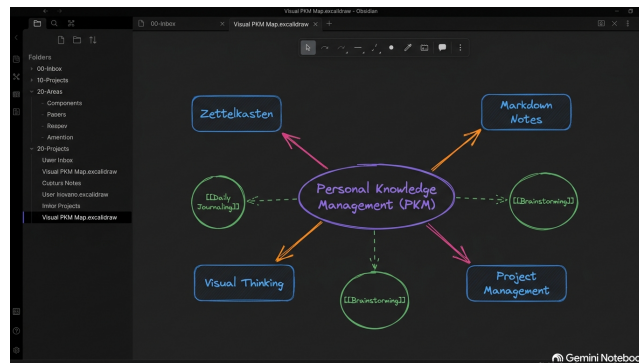


Figure 1: Visual Personal Knowledge Management (PKM) mind map on the Obsidian-Excalidraw canvas, displaying note links and interconnected topics.

3. DIAGRAMMING, CUSTOMIZATION, AND AUTOMATION

- **Diagram Automation:** Instantly convert Mermaid code to editable vector shapes. If you have an OpenAI API key, run the 'Text-to-Diagram' script to automate flowcharts and sequence drawings.
- **Architectural Aesthetics:** Ditch the hand-drawn look for formal reports. Change edges to 'Sharp', stroke slop to 'Architect', and font faces to 'Normal' to achieve a polished corporate style.
- **Deconstruct Selection:** Split your drawing dynamically. The 'Deconstruct Selected Elements' script moves the selected shapes into a separate file and replaces them with an embedded link.
- **Excalidraw Automate (EA):** Open the developer console (Ctrl/Cmd + Shift + I) to run JavaScript macros using EA help files, automating repetitive canvas tasks programmatically.

4. RICH MEDIA INTEGRATION AND ADVANCED ANNOTATIONS

- **PDF Annotation Canvas:** Import PDFs as static page images. Freely organize pages, circle data points, highlight text, and add handwritten annotations directly on the infinite canvas.
- **Source-Linked Crop & Mask:** Extract specific charts or sections from imported PDFs. The cropped image retains an active, double-clickable link back to the exact page of the source PDF document.
- **Web Image Drag-and-Drop:** Drag and drop images directly from web browsers. They are inserted as linked web assets, and clicking them opens their original URL in your browser.
- **Custom Fonts & Highlighters:** Register custom .ttf files in settings as a fourth default font. Configure highlighters and custom pen settings by double-clicking the toolbar pen icons.

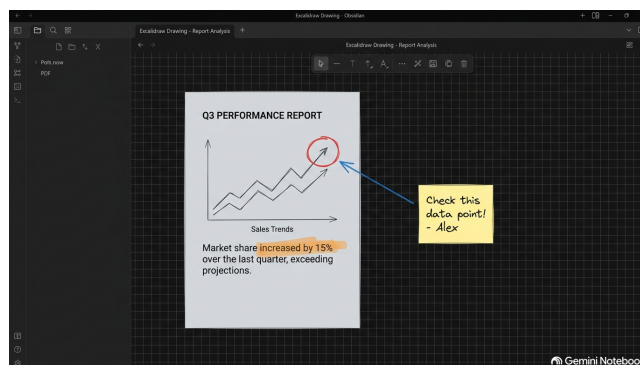


Figure 2: Annotation workspace displaying an imported PDF performance report with hand-drawn highlights, sticky notes, and comments on the grid canvas.

5. COMMUNITY POWER (THE SCRIPT STORE AND ADVANCED TOOLS)

- **Slideshow Presentation Script:** Define presentation frames by drawing arrows. The arrow's point pairs mark the slide bounds and direction, enabling immediate slide shows.
- **Advanced Geometry Scripts:** Install 'Split Ellipse' (cut shapes using drawn lines), 'Boolean Operations' (add/subtract overlapping shapes), and 'Repeat Elements' to batch-duplicate size/rotation transformations.
- **Select Elements of Type:** Isolate elements quickly. Narrow your current selection down to a specific type (e.g., arrows only) to recolor or style them in bulk.
- **Palette Loader:** Create custom markdown files containing color hex codes, and load them using Palette Loader to maintain consistent design branding across your vault.
- **Invert Colors Eye Care:** Run the 'Invert Colors' script to use dark canvas backgrounds while keeping high-contrast palettes, ensuring optimal readability during night sessions.